of the 28 seats reserved for STs, allowing the Soren-led JMM-Congress-RJD alliance to dislodge it from power. The trend continued in the 2024 general election—in the aftermath of Soren's arrest four months earlier—with the BJP losing all the five Lok Sabha seats reserved for STs. And this despite realising the significance of the tribal vote (albeit belatedly) and appointing Marandi, a Santhal like Soren, president of the state BJP in July 2023.

By contrast, the JMM has traditionally had a strong hold over the state's tribal voters, given that Hemant's father Shibu Soren has been the most prominent tribal leader in Jharkhand. Hemant has built on this legacy by advocating for a domicile policy based on 1932 land records for government job eligibility and pushing for the recognition of the Sarna religion, which seeks a distinct identity for the nature-worshipping tribals. These moves have derailed the BJP project to subsume tribal groups under a broader Hindu identity.

Aware that it is some of this tribal vote that it needs wean away from the JMM, Prime Minister Narendra Modi has already made two trips to the state in the past two months. On the second one, on October 2, he announced the Dharti Aaba Jantatiya Gram Utkarsh Abhiyan, a Rs 79,150 crore welfare initiative that is expected to benefit the 50 million tribals in the country. In addition, say BJP sources, the party is planning at least seven campaign meetings by the PM.

Simultaneously, the party is examining its performance in the various regions where tribal seats are distributed. So, in the Kolhan region, where the BJP was completely wiped out in 2019, losing all the 14 ST-reserved seats, the party is relying on three former tribal CMs—Champai Soren, Arjun Munda and Madhu Koda—to turn fortunes around. Champai, who left the JMM to join the BJP in August, and his son Babulal are contesting from Saraikela and Ghatshila, respectively. Koda, who had toppled the Arjun Munda-led government in 2006 to become CM, is now in the BJP camp alongside the latter. A prominent leader from the Ho tribe, Koda could play a crucial role in strengthening the BJP's presence in the Kolhan region. His wife Geeta and Munda's wife Meera will be contesting from Jagannathpur and Potka, respectively, and are expected to bolster the BJP's prospects in Kolhan.

The Santhal Parganas is the other area of darkness for the BJP. Of the 18 seats here, the JMM won nine and the Congress four in 2019, on the back of strong tribals and minorities support. To break this, the BJP is now floating the slogan 'Roti, Beti aur Maati', suggesting that "Bangladeshi infiltrators" (read Muslims) are marrying their daughters and seizing their lands and jobs. However, the party's hope of fielding Lois Marandi, who had defeated Hemant Soren in 2014 on a BJP ticket, came to nought as she joined the JMM on October 21.

SINCE HIS RELEASE FROM JAIL AND RETURN AS CM, HEMANT SOREN HAS LAUNCHED A SLEW OF SCHEMES. THE MAIYYA YOJANA BENEFICIARIES ITSELF ARE A THIRD OF JHARKHAND'S ELECTORATE

THE JMM COUNTER

Since his release from jail and return as chief minister, Hemant has gone on an overdrive, launching a slew of welfare initiatives. In August, his government introduced the Maiyya Samman Yojana, a cash transfer scheme providing Rs 1,000 per month to women between the ages of 18 and 50. Just a day before the Election Commission announced the poll dates, the Soren cabinet promised to raise the stipend to Rs 2,500 per month from December onward. Other initiatives include waiving Rs 3,584 crore in unpaid electricity dues for nearly four million households, providing 200 units of free electricity to underprivileged families, and waiving Rs 400.66 crore of agricultural loans for 176,977 farmers.

The number of beneficiaries is significant. At 5.3 million, the *labharthi*s of just Maiyya Samman are nearly a third of the 15 million votes cast in the 2019 state election and equivalent to the number of votes the JMM-Congress-RJD alliance polled.

As Suman K. Shrivastava, former advisor to the Jharkhand CM and guest faculty at a private university, says: "The BJP appears to have forged a smooth alliance, but their greater challenge lies in countering Soren's goodwill among beneficiaries of the government's schemes." To counter that, the BJP has announced its 'paanch pran' or five resolutions: providing universal basic income to women, cooking fuel, jobs, unemployment allowance and housing.

As Hemant faces a formidable line-up of local BJP leaders, who will be joined by top central leaders for campaigning, giving him significant strength will be wife Kalpana, who emerged a leader in her own right while he was in jail. Her seamless connect with women voters, with whom she can often be seen sharing a meal, is expected to rally the female voters behind the JMM. "The purpose of this journey is to give dignity and respect to half the population," she has said.

The main battle apart, several legacy battles will decide the political fate of individuals. There is Marandi, for one, who stepped down in 2003 after serving as the state's first CM, and has done nothing of significance since. Should the BJP perform well, he has a chance to reclaim the top post. Three-time CM and former Union minister Arjun Munda, after losing his LS seat this time, will need a strong showing this election to retain political relevance. Among the legacy battles, the one Hemant's estranged sister-in-law Sita is mounting will be the one to watch out for. Though she lost the LS poll, she is soliciting votes in the name of her late husband Durga Soren, eldest son of Shibu Soren. ■